

Assignment 6: Synthesis

Thesis: *Typographic Archives of Latino Life: New Media Alphabets in Southwestern Ontario*

Topic and Justifications

This thesis examines how co-designed alphabets developed with Latino residents along the London-Sarnia corridor can document everyday life, question dominant typographic norms, test multilingual readability, and support ethical forms of representation.

The project developed from a broad interest in typography and representation into a more focused research-creation framework with clearer methodological and ethical grounding.

The work is organized through five interconnected inquiries:

1. **Typography as archive**
This inquiry asks how typography can function not only as communication, but also as archive, evidence, testimony, and cultural record.
2. **Who defines good typography**
This inquiry examines how typographic quality, readability, correctness, and professionalism are shaped by institutions, dominant languages, and inherited design traditions rather than existing as universal standards.
3. **Typographic mechanics and multilingual reading**
This inquiry studies spacing, hierarchy, contrast, rhythm, paragraph structure, and other typographic mechanics as both technical and political decisions, since they reveal whose reading habits and language norms are being prioritized.
4. **Ethical visibility**
This inquiry considers how representation can support visibility without becoming extractive, reductive, or detached from participants' agency.
5. **Corridor life as visual ecology**
This inquiry understands the London-Sarnia corridor not simply as a backdrop, but as a lived environment shaped by commuting, labour, storefronts, churches, homes, and roadside signage that actively informs the project's visual references and letterforms.

Each of these inquiries expands the project by identifying a hypothesis, a claim, and an explanation of why the question matters.

Ways of Making and Methods

During the semester, I explored two main ways of making alongside related methodologies: **printmaking** and **type design with typographic mechanics and variable font testing**.

1. Printmaking

Printmaking allowed me to explore *Otava* as a material and embodied typeface. Through this process, the typeface revealed texture, repetition, rhythm, and physical presence in ways that go beyond the screen. This became especially visible through the exhibition *[LAB]YRINTH*, where the work moved into installation, proofing, and public display.

2. Type Design, Typographic Mechanics, and Variable Font Testing

Type design, typographic mechanics testing, and variable font development supported the growth of *Otava* as both a conceptual and functional typeface. This process focused on spacing, hierarchy, legibility, multilingual character support, proofs, and specimens, while also using variable font workflows to test how the typeface behaves across different formal conditions. Working with Glyphs, RoboFont, Fontra, UFOs, and designspace logic allowed me to connect drawing, interpolation, testing, and export as part of one continuous process. Bringing variable font testing into this method helped me understand the typeface not only as a fixed form, but as a flexible system that can be adjusted, refined, and evaluated across multiple settings. This method connected the conceptual aims of the thesis with the formal and technical decisions involved in building a typeface.

Bibliography and What It Supports

- **Typography as archive and discourse**
Waller, Beier, Spencer, Merleau-Ponty, and Nat Pyper support the idea of typography as evidence, memory, and co-created record.
- **Typographic quality and mechanics**
Lund, Macdonald-Ross and Waller, Beier, Hochuli, and Ambrose, Harris, and Theodosiou support discussions of legibility, detail, hierarchy, spacing, and the critique of typographic norms.
- **Ethics and decoloniality**
Escobar, Schultz et al., Tashakkori and Teddlie, Tierney and Clemens, and Walford support the project's thinking around visibility, consent, representation, and non-extractive participation.
- **Methods and making**
Print Club London, Kvale, Wheeldon and Ahlberg, Collins and Collins, Drucker, Griffin, Microsoft, Google Fonts, Glyphs, Fontra, TypeCooker, Brownie, and Wang support the project's methods in printmaking, interviews, mapping, type specimens, variable fonts, and motion.